THE COURAGE ECONOMY

Incentive Inventory

What you say versus what you actually reward

How to Use This Inventory

The Lie Economy Inventory showed you what is broken. This Incentive Inventory reveals why. Lies are not random. They are produced by a system of incentives you have created, whether you intended to or not.

For each of the ten areas below, complete both columns honestly. Then answer the follow-up question. If your answer makes you uncomfortable, you have found a lie.

Do not do this alone. Ask your people the same questions. The gap between your answers and theirs is the most important data you will collect. Every gap is a lie, and every lie costs you something.

After you finish, go to the Protection Audit questions at the end for each gap you found. Understanding what each lie protects is the next step. Changing the incentive without addressing the underlying need will only create a new lie.

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1. Performance

Column A: What We Say	Column B: What We Actually Reward
What do we say great performance looks like?	What actually gets people promoted, praised, or rewarded here?

Follow-up: Think of the last three people who were promoted. Were they promoted because they exemplified what you say you value? Or for something else — loyalty, visibility, political skill, tenure, or simply being liked by the right people? What did their promotions telegraph to the rest of the organization?

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2. Speed vs. Quality

Column A: What We Say	Column B: What We Actually Reward
What do we say about the importance of doing things right?	What happens to the person who misses a deadline because they did it right versus the person who hits the deadline with a flawed product?

Follow-up: When things go wrong because someone cut corners to meet a deadline, what are the actual consequences? A write-up that goes nowhere? Now compare that to what happens when someone misses a deadline. Which consequence is worse in your organization? Your people already know the answer.

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3. Feedback and Truth-Telling

Column A: What We Say	Column B: What We Actually Reward
What do we say about the value of honest feedback and open communication?	What happened to the last person who told a senior leader something they didn't want to hear?

Follow-up: If you asked your team to name one thing they would never say to your face, could they come up with something? If the answer is yes, then your stated commitment to honesty is a lie. Not because you are a bad person, but because your system punishes the very thing you say you want.

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4. Innovation and Risk

Column A: What We Say	Column B: What We Actually Reward
What do we say about innovation, creativity, and taking bold action?	What happened to the last person whose bold idea failed?

Follow-up: Can you name a specific instance where someone took a risk, failed, and was visibly supported or rewarded for having tried? If you cannot, your people have already done the math. The rational move in your organization is to play it safe. And they are.

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5. Collaboration vs. Individual Achievement

Column A: What We Say	Column B: What We Actually Reward
What do we say about teamwork, collaboration, and working together?	Who gets the visibility, the credit, and the promotion — the team-builder or the individual performer who makes sure leadership knows about it?

Follow-up: How many of your recognition mechanisms — awards, shout-outs, bonuses, promotions — reward individual achievement versus genuine collaborative effort? If heavily weighted toward individuals, you are telling your people that collaboration is a nice thing to say but not a serious path to advancement.

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6. Development

Column A: What We Say	Column B: What We Actually Reward
What do we say about developing our people and building the pipeline?	When budgets get tight, what is the first thing cut? When a leader fails to develop their people but hits their numbers, what happens?

Follow-up: Has a leader in your organization ever been passed over for a promotion because they did not develop their people? If the answer is no, then development is not something you actually value. It is something you talk about. Your people know the difference.

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7. Work–Life Balance

Column A: What We Say	Column B: What We Actually Reward
What do we say about respecting boundaries and sustainable workloads?	Who gets the high-visibility assignments and promotions — the person who delivers within normal hours, or the person who is always available and always visible?

Follow-up: If someone consistently left at five, took their vacation, and did not answer emails on weekends — but delivered outstanding results — would they advance at the same rate as someone who was always on? If no, then your commitment to work–life balance is a tax your people pay with their personal lives.

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8. Accountability

Column A: What We Say	Column B: What We Actually Reward
What do we say about holding people accountable and maintaining standards?	How long has your longest-tenured poor performer been in their role? What has actually happened to them?

Follow-up: Your people know who the poor performers are. They always do. And they know that you know. Every day that person remains unaddressed, you are telling the rest of your organization that accountability is optional, standards are negotiable, and the people who carry the weight are suckers for doing so.

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9. Autonomy and Empowerment

Column A: What We Say	Column B: What We Actually Reward
What do we say about empowering our people and trusting them to make decisions?	How many decisions does your team actually make without your approval? When they decide differently than you would have, what is your reaction?

Follow-up: Think about the last time a team came to you with a recommendation that differed from what you wanted. Did you accept it? Override it? Accept it publicly and quietly undermine it? Your people remember, even if you don't.

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10. Values and Culture

Column A: What We Say	Column B: What We Actually Reward
What are your stated values — the ones on the wall, on the website, in new hire orientation?	Describe, in specific behavioral terms, how each value is actually practiced. Not how you wish it were. How it actually is.

Follow-up: For each value, can you point to a specific instance where someone was rewarded for living that value when it was costly? Can you point to where someone was held accountable for violating it, even when they were otherwise a high performer? If not, your values are decoration. They are not culture.

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The Protection Audit

Go back to every row where Column A and Column B do not match. For each gap, answer the three questions below. Do not do this alone. Bring your team into the room. They know which lies are protecting which people.

1. What does this lie protect?

Be specific. Not “it protects people’s comfort.” That is another lie. What does it actually protect? Someone’s job? Someone’s reputation? A leader’s ability to avoid a difficult conversation? A department’s budget? A VP’s narrative to the board? Every lie has a beneficiary. If you cannot name them, you have not gone deep enough.

2. What would break if this lie stopped tomorrow?

Don’t think about what would improve. Think about what would break. If you stopped rewarding speed over quality tomorrow — with real consequences — what would happen next week? The current incentives exist because they are solving problems your organization actually has. You cannot remove them without accounting for the utility of the lie.

3. Am I willing to pay the cost of closing this gap?

This is the Courage Tax. It is the specific and personal cost to you. Closing the gap on feedback might mean losing a political operator who keeps the senior team happy. Closing the gap on accountability might mean firing someone you have protected for years. Each gap has a price tag. Know what it is before you decide to close it.

Every gap is a lie, and every lie costs you something. The cost of courage is always visible. The cost of the Lie Economy is invisible. It compounds silently. You are now holding both bills

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in your hands. The only question left is: are you willing to pay?

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